

THE WINNERS (From left) Devendra Fadnavis, Eknath Shinde, Yogi Adityanath and J.P. Nadda in a file picture

and also put a feedback mechanism in place. This helped the party identify and address key issues. Party insiders say it also provided RSS leadership leverage in bringing BJP leaders to the discussion table in poll-bound states.

The strategy sweetener in all this was the cash doles and welfare schemes. Both Haryana and Maharashtra dished out versions of the Ladli Behna, the cash dole scheme for women that had been a massive success in Madhya Pradesh. In Maharashtra, it became the Ladki Bahin scheme which transferred Rs 1,500 every month to 23 million women beneficiaries with a promise of a top-up of Rs 600 and expanding the number of beneficiaries by 2 million.

The election in Maharashtra also marks a return to the party's polarising agenda, though couched in the euphemistic slogan of '*Ek hai toh safe hai*'. PM Modi reiterated it in his victory speech after the Maharashtra election, saying, "The voters of Maharashtra have stopped the conspiracy hatched by the Congress and their friends. Maharashtra has given a verdict—'*Ek hai toh safe hai*' is India's mantra." The BJP-RSS had realised the slogan's resonance during the Haryana polls, where the war cry had enthused the party cadre. Critics, of course, charge the BJP of returning to its old game of pitting Hindu voters against Muslim ones. They argue that it is the antithesis of the '*Sabka saath, sabka vikas*' plank on which Modi rode to power. BJP insiders counter that the pitch is an attempt to make party sympathisers aware of "global threats" and "reverse polarisation", especially with minority votes coalescing in favour of the INDIA bloc over issues like Ayodhya, the Waqf (Amendment) Bill 2024, Uniform Civil Code and anti-conversion laws. The 'unity' call is also seen as a BJP-RSS strategy to divert attention from the Opposition's push for a caste census. The view in the Sangh Parivar has always been that the caste census, by design, was aimed at fragmenting Hindu society.

Fraying at the Seams

Even as the Maharashtra victory overshadowed all else, Jharkhand and the bypoll results show that there is work still to be done. States like West Bengal, Punjab and Kerala continue to elude its grasp. The party is stagnant, even losing ground, in these states that together account for 75 Lok Sabha seats. Add Tamil Nadu, with its 39 LS seats, as an extension of that unbreached frontier. The BJP holds only 12 of these 114 seats—11 in Bengal, one in Kerala. For its Mission 2029 plan to succeed, repairs and recalibrations are crucial.

In the bypolls, the BJP lost in all the seats in Bengal (6), Punjab (4) and Kerala (2). The most painful of these losses will be in Madarihat in north Bengal and Palakkad in Kerala. In Madarihat, a former BJP bastion, the party lost in the absence of a strong narrative and organisational impetus; the fight in Palakkad was marred by massive factionalism. The next two months should see an overhaul of the party organisation in all four states. The knives are already out in Kerala for state president K. Surendran; in Punjab, Sunil Jakhar faces the same fate. The party has no option but to hit the refresh button in these state units, for it's already late. Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala will go to the polls in 2026. Punjab's reckoning will happen in 2027.

The bypoll results showed that the BJP is still struggling in West Bengal, Punjab and Kerala. The party is stagnant, even losing ground

In Bengal, the BJP had hoped to gain, riding on the protests in the RG Kar Hospital rape-murder case, but it was not to be. The party has an aggressive leader in Suvendu Adhikari, but BJP sources say the lack of a Sangh background is a handicap for him in the organisation. In Kerala, the BJP had tasted LS success for the first time with actor-turned-neta Suresh Gopi winning from Thrissur. So there were high hopes for the neighbouring Palakkad assembly seat, where the BJP has always had a strong showing. But here again, infighting seems to have ruined whatever chances they had. Similarly, in Punjab, the BJP had hoped the anti-incumbency vote against CM Bhagwant Mann and the absence of the Akali Dal would help the party gain some ground in the rural belt. But the BJP candidates lost their deposit in three of the four seats. This, despite fielding former ministers Manpreet Badal, Ravikiran Kahlon and Sohan Singh Thandal from their respective strongholds.

But barring these holdouts, the BJP can now truly claim to be the 'superparty' of the country. The back-to-back assembly poll victories have reinforced the belief that the leadership has learned from its mistakes and is nimble enough to make corrections. Next up is a prize ticket, the Delhi assembly election in February, and the RSS-BJP combine will fancy their chances against wounded Aam Aadmi Party frontman Arvind Kejriwal, who'll be looking to make it three terms in a row. The saffron combine has been looking to breach Delhi's gates for a long time. If it happens, one can be sure the celebrations will take a long time to wind down. ■